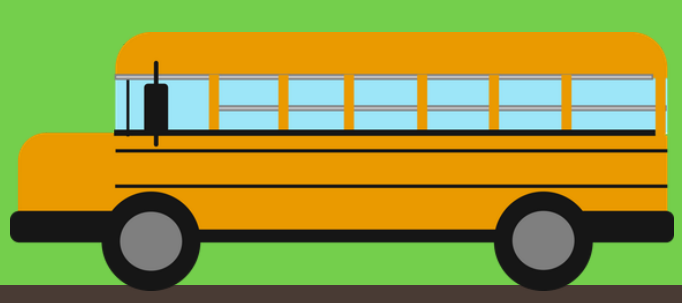


FREEDOM RIDE
Charles Perkins





Earlier activism and the making of Charles Perkins

Fun fact : There is a Charles Perkins Centre on our campus, representing our commitment to his philosophy—collaboration, inclusivity, and continuing challenge the status quo.

Aboriginal activism did not begin with the 1965 Freedom Ride. Earlier organised political action had already challenged state control and argued for more Aboriginal self-determination, so the Ride should be seen as part of a longer history rather than a sudden beginning (Maynard, 2007; Broome, 2010). Charles Perkins grew up within this wider context. The Charles Perkins Centre states that he was born near Alice Springs in 1936. His father was Martin Connelly, and his mother was Hetty Perkins, an Aboriginal woman from the Arrernte people of central Australia. Her upbringing shaped her strong character. She raised her four children in white institutions and according to a white way of life. In her later years, she witnessed the growing confidence and revival of Aboriginal peoples. Charlie Perkins also named his daughter as Hetti Perkins, who has contributed in numerous major Aboriginal art exhibitions



(Read, 2000). He started school in Adelaide in 1945, later played soccer in England and Sydney, and used sport to help support his university studies. In 1966, he graduated from the University of Sydney with a Bachelor of Arts, becoming one of the first Aboriginal people to graduate from an Australian university (Charles Perkins Centre, n.d.). His early life also connects to a wider education history in which Indigenous students faced long-term inequality shaped by colonial and assimilative policies (Bodkin-Andrews & Carlson, 2016).



The Freedom Ride and the exposure of local racism



In February 1965, a group of University of Sydney students in Student Action for Aborigines travelled through regional New South Wales to expose racial discrimination and poor living conditions faced by Aboriginal people (AIATSIS, 2025; Hill, 2024). Charles Perkins, one of only two Aboriginal students at the university at the time, was elected president of SAFA and became the most visible spokesperson during the Ride (AIATSIS, 2025). The group challenged exclusion in public places, including the Walgett Returned Services League and the swimming pools in Moree and Kempsey (AIATSIS, 2025). The vicepresident of Walgett RSL stated that he would never allow Aboriginal people to become members. Charlie and his companions stood outside the RSL with placards, from around 11 am to 6 pm in the heat. Their protest drew both Aboriginal solidarity and support, as well as ridicule and opposition from RSL members (AIATSIS, 2025). In Moree, the students tried to take Aboriginal children into the local pool but were blocked by a council by-law. They then held a three-hour protest and were met by a hostile crowd (Hill, 2024). Their persistent protest led to growing unrest and security threats, forcing the mayor to intervene and sign a motion to overturn the regulation restricting Charlie's protest. This helped remove discriminatory bans, allowing children to access the pool. Ann Curthoys, one of the Freedom Riders, wrote in her diary that their protest was the top news story by 11 o'clock. She noted that the media was a key factor in giving the movement huge exposure and impact (AIATSIS, 2025). Media coverage became a major part of the Ride, because journalists and television crews turned local racism into a national story (AIATSIS, 2025; Hill, 2024; Charles Perkins Centre, n.d.).



Policy, education and racism

The Freedom Ride is important not because it ended racism, but because it exposed racism that was already part of everyday life in New South Wales country towns (AIATSIS, 2025). Bodkin-Andrews and Carlson (2016) argue that discussions of Indigenous disadvantage are often separated from the historical and current racism that shaped these inequalities. They also state that education and research can help reproduce racism when Indigenous identity is resisted and when Western, outsider-based understandings are treated as the main way of explaining Indigenous experience. In this context, the Freedom Ride can be understood as more than a local protest. It publicly revealed the gap between formal ideas of equality and the racism that Aboriginal people still faced in daily life (AIATSIS, 2025).As an Aboriginal activist and student leader, Charles Perkins helped make this racism visible and connected it to a broader struggle for justice and recognition (Charles Perkins Centre, n.d.).



Significance and Legacy



Two years after the Freedom Ride, Australians voted overwhelmingly "Yes" in the 1967 Referendum. The referendum changed two sections of the Constitution so that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples would be counted as part of the population and the Commonwealth could make laws for them. A more careful way to describe this connection is that the Freedom Ride helped build public awareness and pushed these issues into wider national and international view before the vote, rather than acting as the single direct cause of the result. (AIATSIS, 2025; Hill, 2024).Charles Perkins's later life also shows why his influence lasted far beyond 1965. The Charles Perkins Centre states that the last 30 years of his life were made possible by a kidney donation, and that this gift made him even more determined to make a difference for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people. It also records that he worked in the Office of Aboriginal Affairs and, in 1984, became the first Aboriginal person to serve as Secretary of the Department of Aboriginal Affairs. (Charles Perkins Centre, n.d.).For me, this is why Charles Perkins had such a lasting impact. He not only challenged racism in Australia, but also left a message that could speak beyond Australia because struggles for equality, dignity and recognition exist in many societies. His story also has value in education, since it gives students a strong example of courage, leadership and persistence. For ordinary people, his life shows that one person can keep creating change over many years, even after great personal hardship.